

CivicSuite — User Manual

This is the orientation manual for the CivicSuite umbrella repo. It is written in three parts so different audiences can read only what's relevant to them:

1. **For municipal decision-makers** — non-technical overview of what CivicSuite is, what's available today, and what the licensing and sovereignty posture means for your city. 2. **For developers and IT staff** — how the umbrella works, where each module lives, and how to evaluate or contribute. 3. **Architecture reference** — diagrams and dependency rules.

A glossary at the end defines every technical term used.

Part 1 — For municipal decision-makers

What is CivicSuite?

CivicSuite is an **open-source product family** for municipal records and civic operations. It's not one program — it's a planned collection of modules a city can install one at a time, on its own hardware, on its own schedule. Cities never have to send data to a vendor's cloud, never pay per user, and can read or modify the source code anytime.

Today, modules are shipping at different maturity levels: CivicRecords AI is production-usable, CivicCore is the shared platform package, and all 26 catalog modules have runtime-foundation releases. All catalog modules have advanced to v0.1.1 for CivicCore v0.3.0 alignment. We say shipped and planned boundaries plainly below — no roadmap inflation, no vaporware.

What's available today (as of 2026-04-28)

- **civicrecords-ai v1.4.1** — a working, shipping module for managing public records / FOIA requests, now aligned to `civiccore==0.3.0`. Cities can install this today. Repo: <https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicrecords-ai>. - **civiccore v0.3.0** — the shared "platform" package that every module uses. It now ships migrations, the shared SQLAlchemy `Base`, the LLM abstraction, hash-chained audit primitives, source/provenance contracts, offline import/export manifests, export-bundle helpers, and local city profile configuration. It is not a product on its own; you only "install" it as a dependency of a module. Repo: <https://github.com/CivicSuite/civiccore>. - **civicclerk v0.1.1** — a runtime-foundation release for meetings, agendas, packets, minutes, voting, and sunshine-law compliance. It ships the API/schema foundation, compliance guardrails, and live `/staff` workflow screens for intake, packet assembly/export, notice checklist, meeting outcomes, minutes draft, public archive, and connector import; full database persistence/authentication hardening is still planned. Repo: <https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicclerk>. - **civiccode v0.1.1** — a runtime-foundation release for municipal code and ordinance access, now aligned to `civiccore==0.3.0`. It ships source registry, section/version lifecycle, search and permalinks, deterministic citations, citation-grounded Q&A, staff notes, plain-language summaries, CivicClerk handoff intake, resident lookup pages, local import connectors, and records-ready exports. It still does not ship legal advice, live LLM calls, live codifier sync, or automatic ordinance codification. Repo: <https://github.com/CivicSuite/civiccode>. - **civiczone v0.1.1** — a runtime-foundation release for parcel-aware zoning and land-use Q&A, now aligned to `civiccore==0.3.0`. It ships canonical zoning schema, Alembic migrations, sample parcel and rule lookups,

citation-grounded sample Q&A, planner escalation, staff-context samples, and a public sample UI at `/civiczone``. It still does not ship live GIS ingestion, live LLM calls, authentication/RBAC, planner review queues, official zoning determinations, or legal advice. Repo: <<https://github.com/CivicSuite/civiczone>>. - ****civicaccess v0.1.1**** — a runtime-foundation release for accessibility, plain-language, multilingual, and ADA review support, now aligned to ``civiccore==0.3.0``. It ships deterministic sample accessibility review, plain-language rewrite, multilingual variant, records-ready export checklist, and a public sample UI at `/civicaccess``. It still does not ship certified ADA compliance, legal advice, live LLM calls, production translation workflows, document ingestion, or suite-wide integration APIs. Repo: <<https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicaccess>>. - ****civicplan v0.1.1**** — a runtime-foundation release for comprehensive-plan policy lookup and cited planning analysis support, now aligned to ``civiccore==0.3.0``. It ships deterministic sample plan-policy lookup, policy-consistency support, staff-analysis outline helper, records-ready export checklist, and a public sample UI at `/civicplan``. It still does not ship official planning determinations, legal advice, live GIS, live LLM calls, plan document ingestion, permitting-system integrations, or production staff-review queues. Repo: <<https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicplan>>. - ****civicpermit v0.1.1**** - a runtime-foundation release for permit pre-application and intake-readiness support, now aligned to ``civiccore==0.3.0``. It ships deterministic sample permit requirement lookup, intake-readiness review, submittal outline helper, records-ready export checklist, and a public sample UI at `/civicpermit``. It still does not ship permit approvals, legal advice, live GIS, live LLM calls, plan ingestion, production permitting-system integrations, or system-of-record behavior. Repo: <<https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicpermit>>. - ****civicinspect v0.1.1**** - a runtime-foundation release for inspection support, now aligned to ``civiccore==0.3.0``. It ships deterministic sample repeat-case lookup, inspector-owned report draft helper, notice draft helper, records-ready export checklist, and a public sample UI at `/civicinspect``. It still does not ship official findings, citations, fines, notices, inspection scheduling, legal advice, live photo analysis, live LLM calls, or system-of-record integrations. Repo: <<https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicinspect>>. - ****civicgrants v0.1.1**** - a runtime-foundation release for grant opportunity and compliance support, now aligned to ``civiccore==0.3.0``. It ships deterministic sample opportunity triage, eligibility-factor matching, application outline helper, compliance calendar helper, audit-ready export checklist, and a public sample UI at `/civicgrants``. It still does not ship live funder feeds, official eligibility decisions, legal advice, live LLM calls, submission portals, or grant system-of-record integrations. Repo: <<https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicgrants>>. - ****civicprocure v0.1.1**** — a runtime-foundation release for procurement drafting and award-packet support, now aligned to ``civiccore==0.3.0``. It ships deterministic sample RFP drafting, proposal comparison, exception extraction, scoring summary helper, award-packet checklist, and a public sample UI at `/civicprocure``. It still does not ship live vendor portals, official vendor evaluation decisions, legal advice, live LLM calls, e-procurement submission portals, or procurement system-of-record integrations. Repo: <<https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicprocure>>. - ****civiccontracts v0.1.1**** - a runtime-foundation release for contract repository and renewal visibility support, now aligned to ``civiccore==0.3.0``. It ships deterministic sample contract registry, clause topic lookup, expiration tracking, renewal visibility, public-records export checklist, and a public sample UI at `/civiccontracts``. It still does not ship live contract management platforms, official legal interpretation, legal advice, renewal approvals, contract execution workflows, live LLM calls, or contract system-of-record integrations. Repo: <<https://github.com/CivicSuite/civiccontracts>>. - ****civicboards v0.1.1**** - a runtime-foundation release for board and commission administration, now aligned to ``civiccore==0.3.0``. It ships deterministic sample board registry, term review plans, vacancy checklists, attendance summaries, notice/records export checklist, and a public sample UI at `/civicboards``. It still does not ship live agenda systems, appointment decisions, legal advice, official notice publication, meeting system write-back, live LLM calls, or board system-of-record integrations. Repo: <<https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicboards>>. - ****civicnotice v0.1.1**** - a runtime-foundation release for public notice compliance support, now aligned to ``civiccore==0.3.0``. It ships deterministic sample notice registry, statutory deadline plans, publication-readiness checklists, channel planning, notice/records export checklist, and a public sample UI at `/civicnotice``. It still does not ship legal sufficiency decisions, legal advice, live LLM calls, official notice publication, publication-system write-back, or notice system-of-record integrations. Repo: <<https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicnotice>>. - ****civic311 v0.1.1**** - a runtime-foundation release for resident service request support, now aligned to ``civiccore==0.3.0``. It ships deterministic sample request intake, triage suggestions, duplicate-candidate review, department routing checklists,

Open311-compatible export helper, and a public sample UI at /civic311. It still does not ship official dispatch, work-order creation, emergency response, legal advice, live LLM calls, 311 system write-back, or 311 system-of-record integrations. Repo: <<https://github.com/CivicSuite/civic311>>. - **civiccomms v0.1.1** - a runtime-foundation release for public communications support. It ships source-readiness review, meeting summary drafts, ordinance explainers, newsletter scaffolds, FAQ prompts, audience-variant drafts, and a public sample UI at /civiccomms. It still does not ship autonomous publication, campaign or advocacy content, legal advice, certified translation, live LLM calls, social media posting, or communications system-of-record integrations, now aligned to `civiccore==0.3.0`. Repo: <<https://github.com/CivicSuite/civiccomms>>. - **civicdata v0.1.1** - a runtime-foundation release for open-data and transparency publishing support. It ships dataset normalization, data-dictionary drafts, CKAN package metadata drafts, PII/exemption preflight, archive-bundle checklists, publication planning, and a public sample UI at /civicdata. It still does not ship live CKAN publication, BI dashboards, data warehouse storage, autonomous redaction, or external connector runtime, now aligned to `civiccore==0.3.0`. Repo: <<https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicdata>>. - **civichr v0.1.1** - a runtime-foundation release for HR policy support. It ships policy lookup outlines, handbook summaries, job-description drafts, classification references, onboarding/training checklists, intake templates, source review, and sensitive-topic preflight. It still does not ship HRIS, payroll, benefits administration, personnel records management, employment-law advice, personnel-file ingestion, live LLM calls, or external HR/payroll connectors, now aligned to `civiccore==0.3.0`. Repo: <<https://github.com/CivicSuite/civichr>>. - **civicbudget v0.1.1** - budget narrative and transparency support foundation. Ships line-item variance analysis, budget narrative drafts, department memo drafts, hearing packet checklists, resident summaries, optional GFOA checklist support, and accessible public sample UI at /civicbudget. ERP, budgeting system, accounting, payroll, fund accounting, budget adoption, official approvals, live LLM calls, and live finance-system connector runtime are still not shipped, now aligned to `civiccore==0.3.0`. Repo: <<https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicbudget>>. - **civiclegal v0.1.1** - internal legal-record research support foundation. Ships privilege-aware corpus filtering, citation-first city-record search, prior-action lookup, attorney-reviewed memo scaffolds, ordinance comparison checklists, litigation-hold candidate flags, authority citation tracking, and accessible public sample UI at /civiclegal. Legal advice, Westlaw/Lexis replacement, autonomous legal conclusions, court filing, e-discovery management, live LLM calls, live privileged corpus ingestion, and external legal-system connector runtime are still not shipped, now aligned to `civiccore==0.3.0`. Repo: <<https://github.com/CivicSuite/civiclegal>>. - **civicelections v0.1.1** - election administration support foundation. Ships cited voter guidance, candidate filing checklists, worker training Q&A, ballot-summary drafts, campaign-finance summaries, canvass checklists, accessibility review, and accessible public sample UI at /civicelections. Voter registration, ballot marking, tabulation, election conduct automation, campaign finance system of record, official certification, live LLM calls, and election-system connector runtime are still not shipped, now aligned to `civiccore==0.3.0`. Repo: <<https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicelections>>.

What's planned but not started

- 0 additional modules remain uncreated; all 26 catalog repos now exist. See the [module catalog](specs/01_catalog.md) for scope and planned depth.

Every catalog module now has a repo and a version number. Specs still distinguish shipped foundations from planned production-depth behavior.

What this means for your city

- **No vendor lock-in.** You install on your own hardware. If a maintainer disappears, the code is yours. The code license (Apache 2.0) and documentation license (CC BY 4.0) both allow you to fork, modify, and continue using the software indefinitely. - **No cloud dependency.** Modules are designed to run with no

outbound network calls. The default LLM (Gemma 4, served locally via [Ollama](https://ollama.com/)) runs on the city's own machine. - **No per-seat billing.** You add as many users as you need at no marginal cost. - **You evaluate one module at a time.** Don't install the suite — install records-ai, see if it solves a real problem in your clerk's office, and decide whether to install another module later. - **You are responsible for hosting and operations.** This is not a SaaS product. Your IT staff (or a contractor) operates the server. The user manual for each module documents what's required.

Glossary (Part 1)

- **FOIA** — Freedom of Information Act; the federal and state laws that govern public records requests. - **LLM** — Large language model; the AI technology used for things like classifying requests, suggesting redactions, and drafting responses. - **Open source** — software whose code is published publicly under a license that allows anyone to read, modify, or redistribute it. - **Sovereign deployment** — software that runs entirely on hardware the city controls, with no required outbound calls to a vendor.

Part 2 — For developers and IT staff

How the umbrella works

The `civicsuite` repo (this one) is **documentation-only**. It contains:

- The [Charter](CHARTER.md) — the project's founding document. - The [Consistency reference](CONSISTENCY.md) — the audit table of every cross-reference and count, treated as the truth-source. - Specs for the catalog, civiccore extraction, civicclerk, and civiczone in `specs/`. - ADRs (Architecture Decision Records) under `docs/architecture/`. - The [compatibility matrix](docs/compatibility/index.md) — which civicrecords-ai version pins to which civiccore version. - The [GitHub Pages landing site](docs/index.html).

There is no runtime code in this repo. Each module lives in its own repo.

Module repos

| Module | Repo | Status | |---|---|---| | civicrecords-ai | <https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicrecords-ai> | Shipping v1.4.1, aligned to `civiccore==0.3.0`. Transferred to the `CivicSuite` GitHub org on 2026-04-25; this is now the canonical home. | | civiccore | <https://github.com/CivicSuite/civiccore> | Shipping v0.3.0 shared primitives: migrations, db.Base, LLM, audit, provenance, manifests, exports, and city profiles. | | civicclerk | <https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicclerk> | Shipping v0.1.1 runtime foundation with live `staff` workflow screens for intake, packet export, notice, outcomes, minutes, archive, and connector import. | | civiccode | <https://github.com/CivicSuite/civiccode> | Shipping v0.1.1 for municipal-code lookup, citations, local imports, records-ready exports, and `civiccore==0.3.0` alignment. | | civiczone | <https://github.com/CivicSuite/civiczone> | Shipping v0.1.1 for parcel-aware zoning samples, public UI foundation, and `civiccore==0.3.0` alignment. | | civicaccess | <https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicaccess> | Shipping v0.1.1 for accessibility review, public UI foundation, and `civiccore==0.3.0` alignment. | | civicplan | <https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicplan> | Shipping v0.1.1 for cited plan-policy lookup, public UI foundation, and `civiccore==0.3.0` alignment. | | civicpermit | <https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicpermit> | Shipping v0.1.1 for permit requirement lookup, intake-readiness review, public UI foundation, and

`civiccore==0.3.0` alignment. | | [civicinspect](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicinspect) | [Shipping v0.1.1](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicinspect) for repeat-case lookup, report drafts, notice drafts, public UI foundation, and `civiccore==0.3.0` alignment. | | [civicgrants](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicgrants) | [Shipping v0.1.1](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicgrants) for opportunity triage, eligibility matching, compliance calendars, public UI foundation, and `civiccore==0.3.0` alignment. | | [civicprocure](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicprocure) | [Shipping v0.1.1](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicprocure) for RFP drafting, proposal comparison, exception extraction, scoring summaries, award-packet checklists, public UI foundation, and `civiccore==0.3.0` alignment. | | [civiccontracts](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civiccontracts) | [Shipping v0.1.1](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civiccontracts) for contract registry, clause topic lookup, expiration tracking, renewal visibility, public-records exports, public UI foundation, and `civiccore==0.3.0` alignment. | | [civicboards](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicboards) | [Shipping v0.1.1](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicboards) runtime foundation for board registry, term tracking, vacancy tracking, attendance review, notice/records exports, public UI foundation, and `civiccore==0.3.0` alignment. | | [civicnotice](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicnotice) | [Shipping v0.1.1](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicnotice) runtime foundation for notice registry, statutory deadlines, publication-readiness checks, channel planning, notice records exports, public UI foundation, and `civiccore==0.3.0` alignment. | | [civic311](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civic311) | [Shipping v0.1.1](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civic311) runtime foundation for request intake, triage suggestions, duplicate-candidate review, department routing, Open311-compatible exports, public UI foundation, and `civiccore==0.3.0` alignment. | | [civiccomms](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civiccomms) | [Shipping v0.1.1](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civiccomms) runtime foundation for source-readiness review, meeting summaries, ordinance explainers, newsletters, FAQs, audience variants, and public UI foundation. | | [civicdata](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicdata) | [Shipping v0.1.1](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicdata) runtime foundation for dataset normalization, data dictionaries, CKAN metadata drafts, redaction preflight, archive checklists, publication planning, and public UI foundation. | | [civichr](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civichr) | [Shipping v0.1.1](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civichr) runtime foundation for HR policy lookup, handbook summaries, job descriptions, classification references, onboarding/training checklists, and intake templates. | | [civicbudget](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicbudget) | [Shipping v0.1.1](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicbudget) runtime foundation for line-item analysis, budget narratives, department memos, hearing packet checklists, resident summaries, and GFOA checklist support. | | [civiclegal](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civiclegal) | [Shipping v0.1.1](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civiclegal) runtime foundation for privilege-aware legal-record search, prior-action lookup, memo scaffolds, ordinance comparison, litigation-hold flags, and citation tracking. | | [civicelections](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicelections) | [Shipping v0.1.1](https://github.com/CivicSuite/civicelections) runtime foundation for voter guidance, filing checklists, worker training, ballot summaries, campaign-finance summaries, canvass checklists, and accessibility review. | | future module depth | planned per module | Production integrations, connectors, persistence hardening, auth/RBAC, and cross-module workflow depth land through module-specific releases. |

Dependency direction

- Modules depend on civiccore. ****Civiccore never depends on a module.**** - This is enforced in CI in the civiccore repo and is documented in the [extraction spec](specs/02_CivicCore.md) section 5.2. - Modules are pinned to a civiccore version in their package manifest. The compatibility matrix is the truth-source for which pin is required for which module version.

How civiccore is consumed

A module like `civicrecords-ai` declares civiccore as a dependency in its `pyproject.toml`:

```
dependencies = [
    "civiccore==0.3.0",
    ...
]
```

When a city installs a module, civiccore is pulled in as a wheel. There is no monorepo, no submodule, no vendored copy. The example above reflects the current post-v0.3 consumer state: all catalog module releases now publish v0.1.1 with `civiccore==0.3.0`. Civiccore is published to PyPI (or, until publication, distributed as a release wheel from its GitHub repo).

Evaluating a module

1. Read the module's `README.md` (start with the front-door pitch). 2. Read its `USER-MANUAL.md` for a non-technical operations walkthrough. 3. Check `CHANGELOG.md` to see release cadence and recent breaking changes. 4. Spin up a local install following the module's `CONTRIBUTING.md` setup steps. The umbrella does not host setup instructions for individual modules — those live with the module. 5. If the module's tests pass on a clean clone, the project meets the umbrella's minimum bar.

Contributing

- **Suite-wide questions, ADRs, governance, roadmap, compatibility matrix** → contribute here. See CONTRIBUTING.md. - **Module bugs, module features, module docs** → contribute on the module's repo. The bug-routing decision tree in CONTRIBUTING.md tells you where each kind of bug goes.

Release coordination

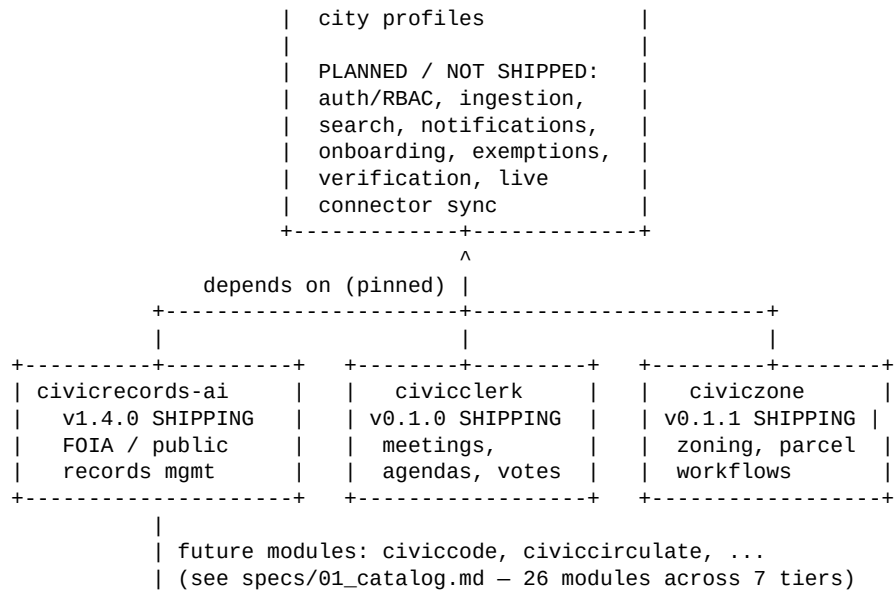
When a module ships a new version, the compatibility matrix on this umbrella must be updated. Cross-cutting changes (e.g. civiccore breaks an API that records-ai uses) require a paired release: civiccore ships first, then records-ai ships pinned to the new civiccore. The release pairing is documented in the matrix.

Part 3 — Architecture reference



Suite topology (textual diagram)

```
+-----+
|  civicsuite (umbrella)  |
|  docs, ADRs, governance, |
|  compatibility matrix   |
+-----+
      |
describes & coordinates |
      v
+-----+
|  civiccore (v0.3.0)     |
|  SHIPPING TODAY:       |
|  migrations, db.Base, llm |
|  audit, provenance,    |
|  manifests, exports,    |
+-----+
```



Dependency rule

****Modules import from civiccore. Civiccore never imports from modules.**** This is the core architectural constraint of the suite. It is enforced by a lint rule in CI in the civiccore repo. Violating it would silently couple modules to each other through civiccore and destroy the modular install promise.

Migration / upgrade order

When civiccore ships a backward-compatible version (PATCH or MINOR):

1. civiccore releases the new version. 2. The umbrella's compatibility matrix is updated. 3. Module maintainers update their pin opportunistically (no forced upgrade).

When civiccore ships a breaking version (MAJOR):

1. The breaking change is announced in advance via an ADR. 2. civiccore releases the new MAJOR version. 3. Each module that consumes civiccore ships a paired MAJOR release pinned to the new civiccore version. 4. The compatibility matrix is updated to show both the old (still supported) and new pairing during a transition window.

Glossary (Part 3)

- ****ADR**** — Architecture Decision Record; a short, dated document recording a significant architectural decision and its rationale. - ****Pinned version**** — a specific exact version a module requires of civiccore (for example `==0.3.0` for current foundation modules, or an older exact pin preserved for historical releases), as opposed to a range. - ****Wheel**** — the standard Python package distribution format. civiccore is published as a wheel. - ****CI**** — continuous integration; the automated test pipeline that runs on every commit and pull request. - ****Monorepo**** — a single repository containing multiple projects. CivicSuite is deliberately *not* a monorepo; each module has its own repo so cities can install modules independently.

What to do when something goes wrong

| Symptom | Where to look | |---|---| | Module won't install | The module's `README.md` and
`CONTRIBUTING.md` setup steps. Most install errors are resolved by matching the documented
Python/PostgreSQL/Redis versions. | | civiccore pin mismatch | The compatibility matrix at
docs/compatibility/index.md. | | You found a bug, don't know where to file |
The bug-routing decision tree in CONTRIBUTING.md. | | Security issue |
SECURITY.md. | | You have a general question | SUPPORT.md. |